

How hard is it to get a visa or tourist card for three to six months? Most countries issue them as a matter of course. Mexico's consular offices around the United States issue six-month tourist cards for the asking. Spain lets you stay for six months with only a passport. Slip over the border to Portugal, France, or Morocco, and when you return to Spain the six months starts over. Argentina grants multiple entry visas good for four years; each trip there can last up to three months. Yugoslavia, as we've said, grants free one-year visas with multiple entry.

In most countries you can keep your tourist status even if you plan a prolonged stay. In Mexico, for example, make sure to head back to the United States before the six months on your tourist card is up. When you return to Mexico, you get a new tourist card and begin a new six-month period. After a year or two you may want to apply for residential status. And after three or four years the Mexicans may refuse to give you any more tourist cards. But most countries welcome Americans who don't want to work and who can show they have a steady source of dollar income from the United States. You need to make sure, though, that the residential status you choose doesn't require you to pay local taxes on interest income earned back in the United States (see below).

HOUSING

The rule on living abroad is:

Rent, don't buy

Chapter 4 talks of the American dream to own your own home. Leave that part of the dream in America. When you go abroad, rent to remain flexible, to avoid exposing yourself to devaluation, and to keep out of legal hassle. If after a few years in a country you insist—like I did—on buying a place to live, keep your total dollar investment as low as possible, certainly below \$30,000.